

A Quantitative Study Of The Creation Of Raghava's Toy Trojan, 2020



Raghava KK

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MY JOURNEY FROM PAINTING TO SCULPTURE OVER 20 YEARS

RAGHAVA KK

ARTIST

BEGINNINGS:

Growing up in Bangalore, art for me was a magical space. A space where morality, understanding and logic gave way to emotional, visceral experiences. I felt I could enter a painting and get lost in it without needing any map. It made me feel alive; it gave me identity and a way to live more intensely than anything else I found around me. My own art making process was an outpouring of my subconscious. Painting without pre-conceiving my works, with my hands, on huge canvases, the results were often surprising even to myself. At that time art was my life and my life was about making art.

However, this relationship with art and life started to get tiresome after an extremely productive decade in. I had become a young celebrity artist in Bangalore, known for a certain kind of composition. Even my unpredictability became predictable. I started to develop intellectual interests that were not woven into my art. I never went to

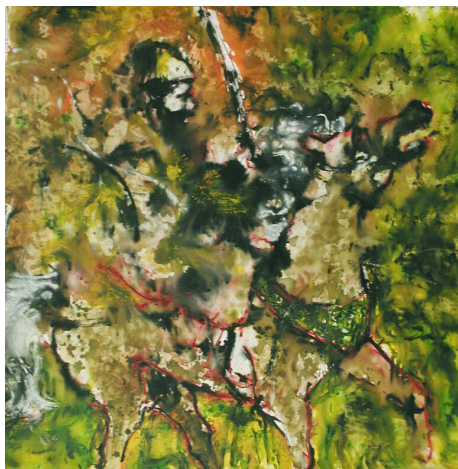


Figure 1: *Moroccan Horseman* - Watercolor On Canvas, 2003

art school; I had no clue of the canned ways of doing this! Raghava the thinker and Raghava the artist were becoming different people. Ideas and outpourings both started to disengage with each other and took on different lives of their own. I was traveling the world giving TED talks on one hand and on the other, I'd create, now with less enthusiasm, my paintings.



Figure 2: *Speaking at TEDMED*, 2013

Move to America : The introduction of the intellect in my art practice

Not being able to bear to continue to enslave myself to even the most lucrative and publicly validating art practice, I tried to use my move to the United States to be with my then partner Netra, who I had fallen in love with, as an opportunity to start acquainting myself with the world of ideas in art, conceptual art, curation and art criticism.

Having had no formal structure or training to engage with this new found world, I limited my conversations on ideas in the arts to Netra's mother (a very left of center English professor) and my friend Tara Kelton, a graduate of The Yale Design school. While my relationship with both of them was eye-opening in introducing me to then dominant art world constructions like power dynamics, concepts of the other, identity politics and academic rejection of the decorative etc. Without noticing it, my spirit withered away leaving in its wake a bunch of learned vocabulary I adopted without feeling strongly for any of it. It was for me, a world in itself, devoid of any inner reality or necessity. vocabulary that I adopted without feeling strongly for any of it. It was for me, a world in itself devoid of any real world interactions. I could not take my hacks to a dinner meeting to entertain or uplift my friends anymore.



Figure 3: *Another Knot In The String Of Time, A Good Three Minutes Ahead Of Me* - Acrylic On Canvas, 2015



Figure 4: *Safety Belt For The Census Bureau* - Digital to Acrylic On Canvas, 2011

My practice changes, I change, and crisis

However I did start to experiment with new ways of making art again. I had taught myself the use of several digital painting and procedural drawing tools. I was blown away by the fact that I could create my own textured brushes on photoshop and play around with

composition through layers. Digital art changed my composition completely and also allowed me to introduce very exciting, fresh and flashy post-human synthetic colors into my mostly traditional and trite palette of raw umber, indian yellow, orange, mauve, crimson red, alizarin crimson, black and white. Now colors like, candy-pink, plastic-yellow neon-blue and toxic-green started to blend in with the earthy tones.

This led to a long journey of creating and refining a digital-physical art making process. One that moved seamlessly between physical painting, digital collage and digital painting. Algorithms and other procedural tools also started to make their marks on my digital creations.

Given I was still showing mostly in India, which still is not very open to digital art now, let alone then, the challenge was then to replicate the final design onto a canvas. Initially through my reluctant labor and then with Padmanabhan, a Pondicherry based painter, who worked with me and was extremely good at reproducing on canvas what I designed on the screen.

While exploring this new style and process was extremely rewarding at the beginning, slowly dissatisfaction set in even here. My inner intellectual life was still largely independent of my art. And worse, I started to realize that the process did not work for me anymore. The transfer from digital to physical medium of a composition designed

digitally, rendered mostly meticulously, lacked energy and play that was so much a part of me. It lacked personality, my personality.

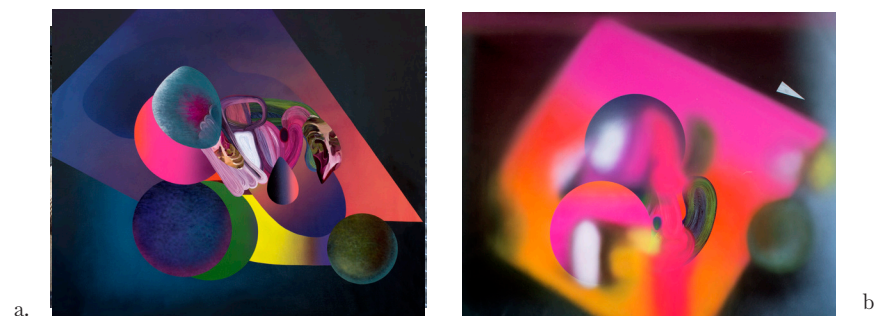


Figure 5: a. *Sublime Machine XI - Digital to Acrylic On Canvas, 2018* b. *Sublime Machine VII - Digital to Acrylic On Canvas, 2018*

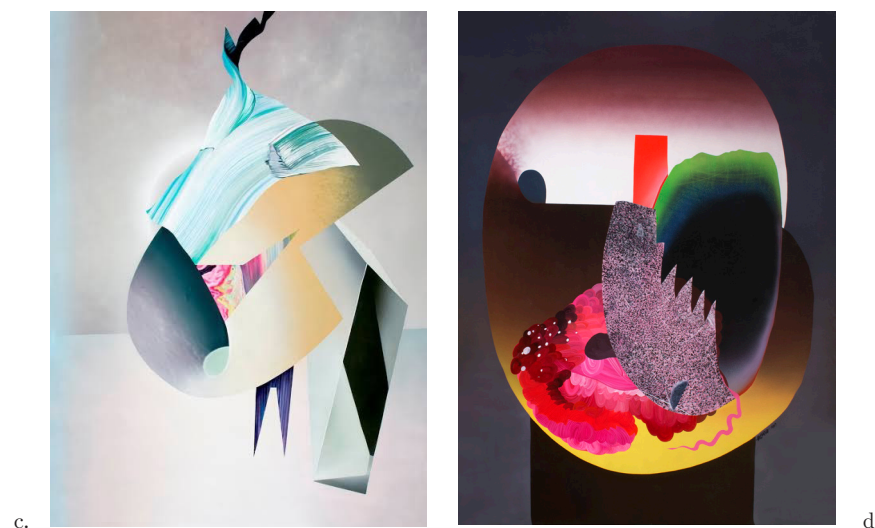


Figure 5: c. *Sublime Machine IV - Digital to Acrylic On Canvas, 2018* d. *Sublime Machine II - Digital to Acrylic On Canvas, 2018*

Figure 6: *My True Self, 2018*

At this same time something else happened that is perhaps the toughest thing I have faced in my life. I had been for 16 years with and gotten married to my first love, Netra. In 2018, when I was traveling abroad, I got a call that changed my life. Netra told me that she wanted to explore a life beyond the ties of our marriage.

My immediate reaction was that of utter disbelief, anger and a deep feeling of rejection, which made me ask myself what validates me and what was my integrity rooted in. Was I fake? Did I have anything to truly believe in? Am I living dual personas? Is everything that I believed in a shallow construction? Was I just another wannabe somebody? Feelings of nihilism and thoughts of suicide suddenly seemed more enticing than any idea of the self.

The move back to India

In the wake of a shattering of what I had assumed to be my identity for 20 years, I did, what most good South Indian boys do when they are in a quandary, go home to Amma and Appa. Co-incidentally my older brother Karthik also was going through the same exhausting journey of separation and had arrived in Bangalore from the United States for the same reason.

Figure 7: *Raghava KK and Karthik Kalyanaraman, 2018*

We lifted each other up from our existential crisis only to realise how much we shared in common when it comes to the power of art. We are both ‘characters’ without a doubt. Where did these personalities come from? What did these constructions of the self add to life? When all learned identities and constructions were destroyed, we still

had something to hold on to: our self-creation. We were suddenly discovering the inbound spiritual energy that we both thought we had lost along the way.

My biggest aha-moment happened when I realised that life and art compliment each other. I realised that Art can hold a more sacred space beyond life. That I owed it to art to find in it an integration of my ideas and feelings, of my personality and intellect, even if life refused me such an integration. Raghava the person works within the structures of society and law, whereas Raghava KK the artist is not restricted to any didactic ideas of right and wrong, instead is only bound to the integrity with which he pursues his acts of making.

Having found that there were values I lived by, values I believed in, it was now my duty to embark on a serious art journey to embody those ideas and ideals in the objects I made. A journey to fuse my intellect and my emotion, my conscious and unconscious selves. I started on a journey to radically change my practice. I wanted my art to integrate— in process, in artwork, in medium and object—my whole self, my aesthetics, my ideas, my essential being. I include below a brief statement on what it is I want to be able to embody in my art.

The horse you see is the first experiment of mine that I have decided to show, in this journey towards a new artistic self. I don't particularly want to talk too much about my obsession with horses, why I am using sculpted wood for my canvas, and all these other standard artistic self-explanations. Or maybe I will, but elsewhere. For now I just wanted to write about how I got here and the journey I am on. A journey that is and will be consuming me the next several years, which is as far as I can see right now.

EVOLUTION OF MY RELATIONSHIP WITH ART

For me, I see every conscious action of mine as either an act of creating a persona or breaking it. My own life has gone through several inventions and reinventions.

In the past, life events would have a big impact on how far I would push the limits of my art. I feel now, looking back, I would soften the extremes of my art so as not to be judged. Upon slightly deeper introspection, I realised that my art was toned down so that it could more or less imitate life.

For example, whenever I expressed pain, I would only do so to the extent that the veneer of my friendly optimistic personality could afford. I often felt apologetic for over sharing or exaggerating a feeling. This left me feeling like a fake.

It's no surprise that I have moved 21 times since my son Rudra was born. Re-invention was the only way of moving on from one persona to the other when either my life or art could no longer be socially acceptable/ palatable. This balancing act often left me feeling displeased with both. It put tremendous stress on my life and art.

Even when I pushed the limits of pain, it was too stark and not layered with the kind of complexity with which I experienced it. When I expressed pain, I usually left out play. When I expressed play, I left out meaning. When I expressed meaning, I left out superficiality. When I expressed superficiality, I left out personality.

I use the term “personality” and not “true self” when talking about myself because the pursuit of finding the true self was thwarted when every time I created a “true self” identity, I found it lacking “integrity”. Earlier, I tried staying true to myself, which left me very frustrated and confused. Several attempts at looking back at my actions, decisions, feelings and artworks, I tried in vain to trace one thread of “truth” that defined me.

In the world of identity performance and social media influencer circles which I have moved around in, ‘brand’ meant promise. Borrowing from this idea, I started to treat every artwork or body of artworks as a brand promise. The promise of an experiential encounter with a concept (most artists in the art world try to create brands too but with less nakedly capitalistic language, and a lot more hypocrisy). This again failed me miserably as no single concept or a collection of concepts represented my persona.

Having established that the meaning of life is an existential wasteland for me, a big epiphany for me happened when I realised that, within the confines of an art series or artwork, integrity could have very specific goals. I could both live life with specific role-goals and also create art with a sense of staying true to my persona. I’d like to call this moral nihilism (yes! I am giving it a very different meaning than what that phrase usually means)

The meaning of life for the moral-nihilist comes from the performance of their inner light, the God, the spark, the complex coexistence of play, identity performance, pain, and superficiality that gives rise to

meaning. Not a conceptual meaning, but an experience of living out your persona. This might seem like built on nothing, but what else is there to build on?

THE PROCESS: A PHOTO ESSAY

Phase 1 - Sourcing and Carving



Figure 8: Sourcing the right wood; Figure 9: Carving the main frame;
Figure 10: Sanding the main frame



Figure 10: Main frame - ready; Figure 11: Digital sketch of characters on main frame;
Figure 12: Chalk marking to carve characters on main frame

Phase 2 - Wooden Sculpture



Figure 13: Front view; Figure 14: Close up; Figure 15: Side view



Figure 16 - 18: Close up of characters

Phase 3 - Painting The Sculpture

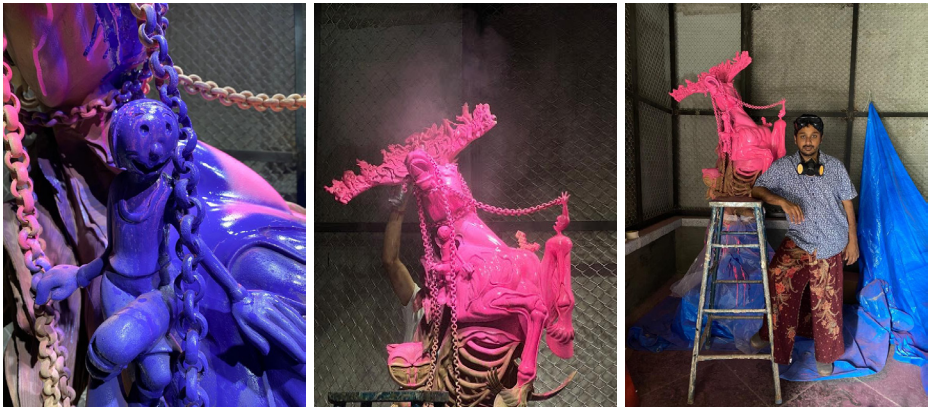


Figure 19: Preparing the sculpture with purple primer ; Figure 20: Painting in progress
Figure 21: Raghava KK in the studio



Figure 22 - 24: Details of painting in progress



Figure 25 - 36: Toy Trojan, 2020



Toy Trojan, 2020

Size: 78.74" x 27.55"

Painting on Wooden Sculpture